The AVAnnotate Project and Creating Access to Culturally Sensitive AudioVisual Collections

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Discovering audiovisual collections is often achieved through contextual metadata. On this panel, project partners describe using AVAnnotate, open-source software that leverages IIIF and GitHub in a minimal computing workflow that produces standards-based, user-generated, online projects that provide sustainable and much-needed commentary and context around under-used and culturally sensitive AV collections.

If scholars, students, and the public do not use audiovisual (AV) collections in libraries, archives, and museums (LAMs), LAMs that hold these diverse collections from a range of timeframes, cultures, and contexts will deem them less important for preservation. Beyond the cost of digitization and technical issues with media playback systems, lack of discoverability or awareness of audiovisual materials is the highest challenge cited by researchers and LAM professionals who seek to make AV artifacts accessible to and usable in research and teaching ("AV Primary Sources: Survey of Academic Libraries 2024"). Librarians, archivists, scholars, and the public often achieve discoverability for AV archives through the difficult and time-consuming work of creating contextual information in metadata and descriptions. Yet, there are few accessible technologies and examples that facilitate creating context for digital AV cultural heritage materials responsibly, ethically, and sustainably in the classroom, in research, or in public contexts. As a result, LAMs are still in the beginning stages of working through the politics, protocols, and systems of how users discover and access AV.

To meet these concerns, the AVAnnotate Project, led by Tanya Clement, Director of the Initiative for Digital Humanities at The University of Texas at Austin, has developed open-source software that leverages the International Image Interoperability Framework (IIIF) standard for AV materials and GitHub in a minimal computing workflow that simplifies the production of standards-based, user-generated, online projects (Clement et. al 2022). These exhibits and editions provide sustainable and much-needed commentary and context around under-used and culturally sensitive AV collections. AVAnnotate project partners from the Fortunoff Video Archive for Holocaust Testimonies at Yale University, the Furious Flower Poetry Center and the Libraries at James Madison University (JMU), LLILAS Benson Latin American Studies and Collections at the University of Texas, and the SpokenWeb partnership members at the University of Alberta and Concordia University, among other partners , have created a set of best practices and documented user-generated projects that accelerate the responsible use of AV and encourage LAMs, scholars, students, and the public to produce and share knowledge about the remarkable and varied AV artifacts LAMs hold. Each of the six panelists will speak to their particular concerns around creating access to and encouraging the responsible use of audiovisual cultural heritage collections.

Access Principles for Audiovisual Collections

Tanya Clement (Director, Initiative for Digital Humanities, University of Texas at Austin) is an Associate Professor in the Department of English at the University of Texas at Austin. She is the Primary Investigator of AVAnnotate. Her book *Dissonant Records: Close Listening to Literary Archives* was published by MIT Press in August 2024.

The Initiative for Digital Humanities team at UT sent out a survey to representatives from AVAnnotate collaborating partner institutions to assess what technical and social issues arise at their local institutions around the process of creating opportunities for increased engagement with sensitive or otherwise restricted AV collections. This survey helped shape the agenda for four virtual and two in-person meetings with partnering institutions who gathered to create "Access Principles for Audiovisual Collections" for institutions creating AV access for research, teaching, and the public. Tanya Clement will introduce the results of the survey and the meetings including the following topics: Sensitive and copyright materials, Accessibility, Preservation and sustainability, and Discoverability for Researchers, Teachers, Institutions, and the Public.

Fortunoff's Annotated Critical Editions Series as a model for AVAnnotate

Stephen Naron (Director, Fortunoff Video Archive for Holocaust Testimonies, Yale) is the director of the Fortunoff Archive, working within the wider research community to share access to the collection through an access site program and digital humanities projects.

The Fortunoff Video Archive for Holocaust Testimonies at Yale University produces critical editions that contextualize video testimonies in their historical time and place. Each testimony in the series is chosen by a scholar, who then produces an original introductory essay about the chosen testimony, along with an annotated transcript and a translation of the unedited video testimony, if in a language other than English. These editions are published as interactive, open access digital publications on a website dedicated to the project: https://editions.fortunoff.library.yale.edu/.

Albeit a rather traditional form of scholarship, annotating texts, the editions are designed to present the text, and the AV source, together in a hybrid publication. In doing so, we aim to encourage researchers to go back to the primary source, which is the video, and not exclusively work with transcripts, which can be misleading. The archive sees it as its ethical obligation to encourage deep and thoughtful viewing of entire or large portions of testimony and discourage viewing of excessively small segments without proper context. This paper will present the critical edition series, and some of the ethical considerations the archive has in its attempt to encourage use of the collection, by leveraging current technology, while maintaining fidelity to the spirit of the agreement with survivors who gave testimony.

Modeling co-creation with the Furious Flower Poetry Center's AV Collection

Yasmeen Shorish (Director of Data & Scholarly Communications, JMU) is a Professor and Director of Data & Scholarly Communications at James Madison University Libraries. Her research focuses on epistemological justice in scholarly communications, data ethics and privacy, and the relationship between information access and power and privilege.

Making AV materials available for annotation requires thoughtful consideration across a range of issues, such as permissions from a legal and ethical lens, agency of the subject of the AV materials, use agreements, and accessibility. The Furious Flower Poetry Center's AV collection has been built through a collaborative relationship between the Center and the Libraries. While topics like description and access are relatively well established between the parties, the issue of poet agency and record authority take on new urgency with the introduction of the AVAnnotate technology.

Poetry, which exists as an art of the written and the spoken word, provides an instructive use case for the development of effective practices and guidelines on use of the technology. The performance of a poet is tightly connected to the intellectual and artistic identity of that individual. Therefore, rights releases and use agreements must be drafted with an extension of care to that relationship. The agency of the creator must be considered to be as pre-imminent as the potential new knowledge production that could come from the annotations.

Thinking about the unintended uses of an annotated video can help guide the development of guidelines and documentation. As the Furious Flower

Poetry Center collection is a continuously growing collection, JMU Libraries has the benefit of continuous dialogue with the Center to ensure that appropriate use statements and access rights are being incorporated with the records and that the AVAnnotate platform is being deployed responsibly in classroom and scholarly contexts.

Saying More About 'Enough Said': Methods for the Community Annotation of Literary Events.

Jason Camlot's (SpokenWeb PI; Professor, Dept. of English, Concordia University) recent books are *Phonopoetics* (Stanford 2019), *Vlarf* (MQUP 2021), the co-edited collections, *Collection Thinking* (Routledge 2023), *Unpacking the Personal Library* (WLUP 2022), *CanLit Across Media* (MQUP 2019), and a recent triple-issue of *English Studies in Canada* on "New Sonic Approaches in Literary Studies" (2023). He directs the SSHRC-funded SpokenWeb Research Partnership.

Jade Palmer (she/her) holds a BA Honours in English and Creative Writing from Concordia University in Tiohtià:ke/Montreal. She won the A.G. Hooper essay prize in 2023 and currently assists with rights management and collections processing at SpokenWeb. Her poetry has won third place in the 2025 Foster Poetry Prize and been shortlisted for the 2024 Austin Clarke Prize. She is the managing editor of *carte blanche* literary magazine.

Audio-visual recordings of literary events may be noisy archival artifacts, but they don't always explain themselves very well. Reading events are as much forms of "ritual communication" (Carey) as aesthetic or semantic. One method for contextualizing such events is to engage with surviving participants in collecting oral histories (Aubin and Fong).

This paper provides an account of methods developed by members of the SpokenWeb research network to annotate an audiovisual collection documenting the Enough Said spoken word poetry series with contextualizing comments and insights provided by a number of the poets and performance artists who performed in the series. Enough Said staged 25 unique events between 1994-1996, each show often representing a different theme or "scene" (Straw) within the wider poetry community of that time. This talk explains the process of "developing" this collection, from the production of descriptive metadata, rights and permissions management, into the organization of community "live"-annotation watch-party events designed to generate annotations on the AV contents by the people documented in the original recordings so they can add stories and memories about what the events meant, and what they mean now. Annotations were made using the low-bar Zoom time-stamped Chat and Full Transcription tools. Annotations were exported and then integrated into a web presentation of the collection that combines time-stamped descriptive metadata of the video contents with the participant-generated annotations, producing a layered annotative presentation of videos documenting one of the first spoken word poetry series in Canada. The presentation thus outlines practical collections development methods designed to use AVAnnotate for extensive "crowd-sourced" community annotations.

Experiments Curating Audiovisual Content Using Aviary and AVAnnotate

Sean Luyk (Digital Curation Librarian, University of Alberta) is responsible for the University of Alberta's Aviary repository, and is a co-investigator on the SpokenWeb project. His research focuses on audiovisual repositories, ethical curation, and sound studies.

The University of Alberta Library's Aviary repository contains over 5000 hours of audiovisual recordings representing a wide range of genres including archival literary audio, podcasts, oral histories, radio and television broadcasts, music recordings, research data, scholarly events, folklore recordings, and more. As an institutional repository, limited resources are available to support the detailed description, interpretation, and contextualization of all collections. This results in an uneven approach to curation where funded collections are well described, and others are not. Low barrier to entry tools such as AVAnnotate, which allow for curation to happen outside the repository, offer promising possibilities for scaling up audiovisual curation work.

This presentation will discuss a series of experiments conducted at the University of Alberta on using AVAnnotate as a cataloguing, indexing, annotation, transcription and curation tool to create and enhance collections in Aviary to make them more discoverable and usable, and likewise, to present these collections in the minimal computing sites that AVAnnotate generates. Building on a series of hands-on AVAnnotate workshops held

at the University of Alberta's Digital Scholarship Centre , and a research assistant hired as an "annotator in residence", the results of these experiments are a series of openly available use cases which articulate the various ways different kinds of users can productively combine Aviary and AVAnnotate in support of curation, and the promotion of audiovisual collections.

Creating Data-rich Latin American Audiovisual Collections for Research and Teaching

Albert A. Palacios (Digital Scholarship Coordinator, LLILAS Benson Latin American Studies and Collections, The University of Texas at Austin) collaborates with faculty, students, librarians, and Latin American partners to develop digital scholarship initiatives. He is also faculty at the School of Information (UT-Austin) and the Masters in Digital Humanities program at the Universidad Nacional de Tres de Febrero in Argentina.

The Benson Latin American Collection at the University of Texas at Austin is home to hundreds of inaccessible audiovisual materials. Increased scholarly and teaching interest in the media has prompted us to initiate several digitization projects to provide open access to these formats as a baseline. However, our goal is to leverage the full potential of digital tools and methodologies to provide various points and layers of access. In the last year, we have been using various machine learning platforms to generate broad and granular metadata for/data from audiovisual collections to not only provide access but enable in-depth research or teaching engagement. We are using the newly relaunched AVAnnotate platform as the interface scholars and students can use to explore and analyze the resulting data-rich collection. For this panel, I will present a case study we have been developing: the annotation of recordings from the Latin American Press Review radio program. Airing from 1973-1984, the broadcast provided a digest of news stories from all over Latin America and the Caribbean and interviews on issues affecting the region. It covered diverse topics, including human rights abuses, economic conditions, music, popular culture, and the history and politics of the region, making it an incredibly rich resource for students of the Cold War in Latin America. The presentation will provide an overview of our workflows, potential research avenues into the collection based on the data we have extracted, and lesson plans we have developed for undergraduate teaching using the AVAnnotate collection.

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